The Complete Catechism Kit

Talking to Your Child About God

The Parents' Guide

Praying, answering their questions, and living the faith as a family



Bonus 5 · Free

A Note for Grown-Ups

For Parents and Catechists



You are the first person to talk with your child about God. The Catechism reminds parents that they have the first responsibility for educating their children, and that teaching the faith begins in the earliest years (cf. CCC 2223, 2226).

You don't have to be an expert. It's not about knowing everything, but about praying with your child, listening to them, and showing them by the way you live that God matters to you.

How to Use This Guide

- **Praying as a Family** (pp. 4-8): simple rituals for morning, mealtime, and bedtime, and a prayer corner at home.
- **The Big Questions** (pp. 9-15): twelve questions children ask, with an answer they can understand and a note for you.
- **The Liturgical Year at Home** (pp. 16-17): a simple idea for each season of the year.
- **Ideas by Age** (pp. 18-20): what to offer at ages 4-6, 7-9, and 10-12, and which book of the kit to open.
- **Our Family Commitments** (p. 21): a page to fill in and put up together.

This guide points you to the other books of The Complete Catechism Kit: the three levels (Pre-Catechesis, First Communion, Confirmation), the 150 Extra Activities, and the bonuses (Prayers, Bible Stories, Games, Coloring Pages). The page numbers given are the ones printed at the bottom of each page.

Tip: Start small. Choose just one ritual this week, and stick with it.

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PRAYING AS A FAMILY

Praying as a Family: Five Keys

Family prayer doesn't need to be long or perfect. These five keys help you keep it simple and steady.

1. **A Set Time**
   Choose a moment that comes back every day: waking up, a meal, or bedtime. The habit carries your prayer on tired days.

2. **A Place**
   A prayer corner, even a tiny one, helps your child understand that this is a special time (see p. 8).

3. **Gestures**
   The Sign of the Cross, folded hands, a lit candle: children pray with their bodies too.

4. **Short and Regular**
   Two minutes every day are better than a long prayer once in a while. Stop before your child gets tired.

5. **Your Example**
   Your child learns most by watching you. Let them see you pray, say you're sorry, and say thank you.

What If My Child Doesn't Want to Pray?

Don't force them, and don't get discouraged. Pray next to them, simply, and invite them to say just a few words: "thank you" or "sorry." The door stays open.

It is in the family that a child first learns to pray (cf. CCC 2685).

PRAYING AS A FAMILY

The Morning Ritual

Mornings are busy. A one-minute prayer, when your child wakes up or before you leave the house, is enough to entrust the day to God.



1. **Wake Up With God**
   Before breakfast, make the Sign of the Cross together.
2. **Say Good Morning to God**
   Pray the Morning Offering together; little ones can simply repeat it after you, phrase by phrase.
3. **Entrust the Day**
   Ask: "What's happening today?" Then entrust it to God in one sentence.
4. **Leave With a Blessing**
   At the door, trace a small cross on your child's forehead.

The Sign of the Cross

In the name of the Father,
and of the Son,
and of the Holy Spirit.
Amen.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 1

Morning Offering

O Jesus, through the Immaculate Heart of Mary,
I offer you my prayers, works, joys,
and sufferings of this day
for all the intentions of your Sacred Heart
in union with the Holy Sacrifice of the Mass
throughout the world,
for the salvation of souls, the reparation of sins,
the reunion of all Christians,
and in particular for the intentions
of the Holy Father this month.
Amen.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 8

Tip: Put the prayer up near the bed or the front door: children who can't read yet learn it quickly by hearing it every day.

Teaching children to pray is part of the mission God gives to parents (cf. CCC 2226).

PRAYING AS A FAMILY

The Mealtime Ritual

Meals often bring the whole family together. It's a natural moment to thank God as a family.



1. **Wait for Everyone**
   Don't start until everyone is seated.
2. **Bless the Meal**
   Make the Sign of the Cross and say grace. Each child can take a turn leading it.
3. **Think of Others**
   Add an intention: for those who cooked the meal, for those who are hungry.
4. **Give Thanks**
   At the end of the meal, say thank you with the Grace After Meals.

Grace Before Meals

Bless us, O Lord, and these thy gifts,
which we are about to receive
from thy bounty
through Christ our Lord.
Amen.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 10

Grace After Meals

We give thee thanks,
for all thy benefits,
Almighty God,
who live and reign for ever.
Amen.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 11

Tip: At a restaurant or at a friend's house, a quiet Sign of the Cross is enough: your child learns that we can pray anywhere, without making a fuss.

PRAYING AS A FAMILY

The Bedtime Ritual

In the evening, five minutes are enough. What matters most is not how long the prayer is, but how consistent it is: the same time, the same place, the same gestures.



1. **Settle Down**
   Turn off the screens, turn on a nightlight, and make the Sign of the Cross together.
2. **Look Back on the Day**
   Ask three simple questions: "What made you happy today?" "Is there anything you're sorry for?" "Who do you want to pray for tonight?"
3. **Pray Together**
   Pray the Bedtime Prayer, and have your child repeat it phrase by phrase.
4. **Give a Blessing**
   Trace a small cross on your child's forehead before turning off the light.

Bedtime Prayer

Today I played with my friends
and had lots of fun.
Thank you, Lord, for everything.
Watch over me tonight.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 9

Tip: For older children, add the "Guardian Angel Prayer" (Bonus 1, p. 7). If your child is tired, keep it short: a Sign of the Cross and a "thank you" are enough. A short prayer every night is better than a long one once in a while.

Praying together at home each day is often the first way young children experience the Church as a praying family (cf. CCC 2685).

PRAYING AS A FAMILY

A Prayer Corner at Home

For personal prayer, the Catechism suggests a "prayer corner" with a Bible and some holy images; at home, a little space like this also helps the whole family pray together (cf. CCC 2691).



What to Put There

- [ ] A cross
- [ ] A picture or statue of the Virgin Mary
- [ ] A Bible, or a children's Bible
- [ ] A candle, lit only when an adult is present
- [ ] A cloth in the color of the liturgical season: violet, white, green, or red
- [ ] Your children's drawings and prayer intentions

How to Set It Up

1. Choose a quiet spot at a child's height: a shelf or the corner of a dresser.
2. Set it up with your children: they will care about it more.
3. Change the cloth with each liturgical season (see pp. 16-17).
4. Keep it simple and tidy: it isn't a decoration, it's a place to meet God.

Tip: Add a small intentions box. Everyone can slip in a note with a name or a thank-you; you can read them together at Sunday prayer.

THE BIG QUESTIONS

How to Answer Their Questions

Children ask real questions, often at the most unexpected moment. You don't need to know everything to answer well.

1. **Welcome the Question**
   A question about God is good news: your child is searching. Thank them for asking.

2. **Ask What They Think**
   "What do you think?" Their answer shows you what they really need to hear.

3. **Keep It Short**
   One or two sentences are enough. If they want to know more, they'll come back with another question.

4. **Tell the Truth**
   Don't make up an answer to reassure them. When the Church has no precise answer, say so simply.

5. **Don't Be Afraid to Say "I Don't Know"**
   "I don't know. Let's find out together." You can also talk with your pastor or a catechist at your parish.

6. **End With a Prayer**
   A big question can become a prayer: "Lord, help us understand."

How to Read the Next Pages

For Your Child: a simple answer to put in your own words.

For You: what the Church teaches, to go deeper.

CCC: the numbers refer to the paragraphs of the Catechism of the Catholic Church.

THE BIG QUESTIONS

The Mystery of God



Two questions about the mystery of God. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"Where is God?"

For Your Child

God doesn't live in one particular place, like a house or a country. He is bigger than the whole sky, and at the same time he is very close to you, deep in your heart. When you talk to him, he always listens.

For You

In the Our Father, the words "who art in heaven" do not point to a place. As the Catechism explains, heaven here "does not mean a place ... but a way of being; it does not mean that God is distant, but majestic." God is infinitely greater than everything he made, and at the same time he is closer to each of us than we are to ourselves (cf. CCC 300). Point to the sky, then place your hand on your child's heart: those two gestures show the two sides of the answer.

CCC 300, 2794

"Why can't we see God?"

For Your Child

God doesn't have a body like ours: he is spirit. It's a little like your parents' love: you can't see it with your eyes, but you know it's there. And God showed himself to us in Jesus: when we look at Jesus, we discover who God is. One day, if we are with him in heaven, we will see him face to face.

For You

God is pure spirit: our eyes cannot see him as he is. Everything Jesus said and did reveals the Father. The Church calls the joy of seeing God in heaven "the beatific vision": it is what we hope for. Avoid presenting God as someone who hides; he simply goes beyond what our eyes can take in.

CCC 370, 516, 1028

THE BIG QUESTIONS

God and Jesus

Two questions about who God is. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"Who made God?"

For Your Child

No one made God. Everything God made has a beginning: you, the trees, the stars. But God has no beginning, and he will never end. He has always existed, and he is the one who made everything.

For You

The Catechism explains that God simply is, in all fullness, without beginning or end, while every creature receives from him everything it is and has. Your child's question is one that philosophers ask: take it seriously, and wonder at it together.

CCC 213

"Is Jesus really God?"

For Your Child

Yes. Jesus is the Son of God. He became a man like us: he was a baby, he grew up, he got hungry and sleepy. But he is also truly God. That is why he could calm the storm, heal the sick, and forgive sins.

For You

Jesus is not part God and part man: he is truly God and truly man. This is the heart of the Christian faith. With younger children, start with the Gospel stories (Bonus 2: Jesus Calms the Storm, p. 36); with older ones, read "The Apostles' Creed" (Bonus 1, p. 5) together.

CCC 464

THE BIG QUESTIONS

Prayer and the Mass

Two questions about our relationship with God. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"Why pray if God already knows everything?"

For Your Child

God already knows what you need. But he loves it when you talk to him, the way your parents love it when you tell them about your day. Praying isn't teaching God something new: it's spending time with him, like talking with a friend.

For You

God knows our needs before we ask, and yet he waits for us to turn to him, because he respects our freedom. In prayer, it is God who seeks us first. Tell your child, too, that God doesn't always answer the way we would like, but that he always wants what is good for us.

CCC 2560, 2736, 2737

"Why do we have to go to Mass?"

For Your Child

Sunday is the day Jesus rose from the dead. At Mass, God's whole family comes together: we hear God's Word, we pray together, and Jesus gives himself to us in the Eucharist. Every week, we get to be with him.

For You

The Eucharist is "the source and summit of the Christian life." The Church asks the faithful to take part in Mass on Sundays and holy days of obligation, unless there is a serious reason such as illness or caring for a baby. Read Sunday's Gospel with your child ahead of time (the daily readings are on the USCCB website), and talk about it at the table afterward.

CCC 1167, 1324, 2180, 2181

THE BIG QUESTIONS

Evil and the Cross

Two hard questions that children often ask after something sad has happened. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"Why is there evil in the world?"

For Your Child

God created a good world, and he made us free. Sometimes people choose what is wrong instead of what is good, and that makes others suffer. There are also illnesses and accidents that no one wanted. God does not like evil, and he doesn't leave us alone: Jesus came to overcome evil.

For You

The Catechism admits that no quick answer is enough: only the Christian faith as a whole can answer it. The evil people choose never comes from God, and faith tells us that he can bring good even out of evil. When your child faces a real sorrow, listen to their pain first: compassion comes before explanations.

CCC 309, 311, 324

"Why did Jesus die on the cross?"

For Your Child

Jesus died on the cross because he loves us. He gave his life to free us from sin and to open the way to his Father. And the cross is not the end of the story: on the third day, Jesus rose from the dead! That is why, for us, the cross is a sign of love.

For You

On the cross, God shows that he loves us first, before we have done anything to deserve it, and that his love leaves no one out. With little ones, focus on love more than on suffering, and always tell the story of Jesus' death together with his Resurrection (Bonus 2: The Passion and the Resurrection, p. 40).

CCC 604, 605

THE BIG QUESTIONS

Death and Heaven

Two questions that call for great gentleness, especially after a death in the family. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"What happens when we die?"

For Your Child

When someone dies, their body stops living, but their soul does not die: it meets God. We pray for those who have died, that they may be very close to God, and we hope to see them again one day, when the dead will rise.

For You

When we die, body and soul are separated; the two will be united again on the day of the resurrection. Right after death, each person is judged on their life: they enter the joy of heaven, either at once or after a purification, or they are separated from God forever. The Church prays for the dead. With a grieving child, don't say "He's in heaven" as a certainty: speak of hope, and pray together for the person who has died.

CCC 366, 1005, 1022, 1030, 1032

"What is heaven like?"

For Your Child

Heaven isn't a place above the clouds. It means living with God, together with Mary, the angels, and the saints, in a happiness that never ends. No one can fully imagine it. God wants everyone to come there, and we get ready by loving him and loving others.

For You

Heaven is the fullness of life with God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—shared with the saints, the angels, and Mary. No picture can capture it: that is why the Bible speaks of it in images (light, peace, a wedding feast, the Father's house). Present heaven as a hope and a calling, never as an automatic reward or as a threat.

CCC 1024, 1027, 1058

THE BIG QUESTIONS

Animals and Forgiveness

Two questions from the heart. Read the "For You" note first, then answer in your own words, using the "For Your Child" answer as a guide.

"Will my dog go to heaven?"

For Your Child

Your dog is one of God's creatures, and God takes care of him. Jesus didn't tell us what happens to animals after they die, and the Church has no precise answer. But we know that God is good and loves everything he made. You can tell him how sad you are and thank him for your dog.

For You

The Church has no defined teaching about what happens to animals after death. The Catechism reminds us that animals are creatures of God, who watches over them with care, and that the whole visible world is meant to be transformed at the end of time. Don't promise your child that they will see their pet again, and don't tell them it's impossible either: welcome their grief.

CCC 2416, 1046, 1047

"Does God still love me when I misbehave?"

For Your Child

Yes, always. God doesn't like the wrong things you do, but he never stops loving you. When you do something wrong, he waits for you with open arms. You can tell him "I'm sorry" in your prayer and receive his forgiveness in the sacrament of Reconciliation (Confession), when you are ready.

For You

The whole Gospel tells of a God who goes looking for sinners to forgive them. Never tie God's love to your child's good behavior ("God doesn't love you when you lie"): it isn't true, and it damages their image of God. Separate the person, who is always loved, from the action, which can be wrong. Say the "Act of Contrition" (Bonus 1, p. 6) together.

CCC 1846, 1847, 1422

THE LITURGICAL YEAR AT HOME

Advent, Christmas, and Lent

Over the course of the year, the liturgy takes us through the whole life of Christ. Here is one simple idea for each season to try at home (cf. CCC 1168, 1171).



Advent color: violet

The four weeks before Christmas (from November 29, 2026)

Set up an Advent wreath and light one more candle each Sunday, with a short prayer. Build the Nativity scene little by little: Baby Jesus is placed in it only on Christmas night.

Bonus 2: The Annunciation, p. 24

Christmas color: white

From Christmas to the Baptism of the Lord (January 10, 2027)

On Christmas night, place Baby Jesus in the manger and read the story of his birth together. On the Epiphany (Sunday, January 3, 2027), add the Wise Men.

Bonus 2: The Birth of Jesus, p. 26

Lent color: violet

The forty days before Easter, from Ash Wednesday (February 10, 2027)

As a family, choose one concrete step for each of the three forms of penance: prayer, fasting by giving something up, and almsgiving with a jar or rice bowl for those in need (cf. CCC 1434).

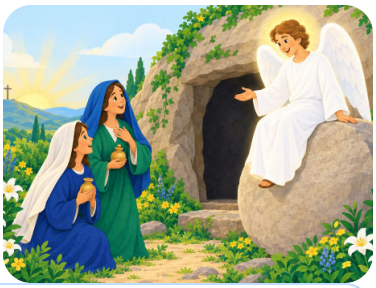
"Act of Contrition" (Bonus 1, p. 6)

If you have the kit's Liturgical Year Calendar 2026-2027, put it up near the prayer corner: it shows each season, its color, and its feasts.

THE LITURGICAL YEAR AT HOME

From Easter to Ordinary Time

The heart of the year is Easter: the Resurrection of Christ lights up all the other seasons.



Holy Week color: red on Palm Sunday and Good Friday; white on Holy Thursday and at the Easter Vigil

From Palm Sunday (March 21, 2027) to Easter

On Palm Sunday, bring home the blessed palms and place them near the family cross. On Good Friday, keep a moment of silence as a family before the cross.

Bonus 2: The Passion and the Resurrection, p. 40

Easter Time color: white

The fifty days from Easter (March 28, 2027) to Pentecost

On Easter morning, greet each other with "Christ is risen!" "He is truly risen!" Put flowers in the prayer corner and keep it white for all of Easter Time. The Ascension: Thursday, May 6, in some ecclesiastical provinces; Sunday, May 9, in most of the United States.

Sunday, the day of the Resurrection (cf. CCC 1166, 1167)

Pentecost color: red

Fifty days after Easter (May 16, 2027)

In the days before the feast, pray "Come, Holy Spirit" together. On Pentecost, put a red cloth in the prayer corner.

"Come, Holy Spirit" (Bonus 1, p. 12) · Bonus 2: Pentecost, p. 42

Ordinary Time color: green

The rest of the year

Make Sunday a special day: Mass as a family, a nicer meal, an outing together. Celebrate each child's patron saint on their feast day too.

The family rosary: "How to Pray the Rosary" (Bonus 1, p. 22)

IDEAS BY AGE

Ages 4-6: Discover

At this age, children discover God through their senses, through gestures, and through their parents' love. Above all, they need to know that God loves them.



What Helps

- Simple gestures: the Sign of the Cross, folded hands, a flower placed in the prayer corner.
- Very short prayers, repeated every day (see pp. 5-7).
- Stories told with pictures: Creation, Noah, the birth of Jesus.
- Drawing and coloring: talk with them about what they are coloring.
- Saying thank you: every night, find three reasons together to thank God.

With the Kit

- Pre-Catechesis (ages 4-6): one activity to do together, at their own pace.
- Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children: "The Sign of the Cross" (p. 1), "Bedtime Prayer" (p. 9), "Grace Before Meals" (p. 10).
- Bonus 2: The Creation of the World, p. 4; Noah's Ark, p. 8.
- Bonus 4 · Coloring Pages: a picture for each story of the faith.

A phrase to repeat often

God loves me, and he is always with me.

IDEAS BY AGE

Ages 7-9: Understand

This is the age of the first real questions. Many children also prepare for First Reconciliation and First Holy Communion, usually in 2nd grade, through the parish religious education program. Children this age love to understand and to do things on their own.



What Helps

- Learning the essential prayers by heart: the Our Father, the Hail Mary, the Glory Be, and the Act of Contrition for First Reconciliation.
- Understanding the Mass: prepare for it together, and explain the gestures and the objects.
- Getting ready for the sacrament of Reconciliation with a short look back at the day each evening (see p. 7).
- Reading a Gospel story and talking about it at the table.
- Discovering the rosary: just one decade as a family, in the evening.

With the Kit

- First Communion (ages 7-9): illustrated stories, the sacraments, the rosary, and the essential prayers.
- Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children: "The Our Father" (p. 2), "The Hail Mary" (p. 3), "Act of Contrition" (p. 6), "How to Pray the Rosary" (p. 22).
- Bonus 2 · Illustrated Bible Stories: one story a week, with its questions.
- Bonus 3 · Catechism Games: word searches, crosswords, and mazes.

A phrase to repeat often

Jesus is waiting for me at Mass and in my heart.

IDEAS BY AGE

Ages 10-12: Choose

Preteens want reasons, and they sometimes pull away. They need to be taken seriously, and they need role models and responsibilities. The age for Confirmation varies by diocese.



What Helps

- Honest answers to their objections: don't avoid their questions (see pp. 9-15).
- Role models: the lives of the saints, including young saints close to their age.
- A more personal prayer: a time of silence, a Gospel passage read on their own.
- Responsibilities: leading grace at meals, taking care of the prayer corner, becoming an altar server.
- Serving others: a project to help people in need, chosen together.

With the Kit

- Confirmation (ages 10-12): the gifts of the Holy Spirit, the Ten Commandments, the saints.
- 150 Extra Activities: for the seasons and feasts of the year.
- Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children: "Come, Holy Spirit" (p. 12), "Act of Faith" (p. 18), "Act of Hope" (p. 19), "Act of Love" (p. 20).

A phrase to repeat often

I choose to follow Jesus.

Our Family Commitments

Fill in this page together, then put it up near the prayer corner. Read it again at the start of each liturgical season.

Our family: _____

Our prayer time: _____

Our prayer corner: _____

Our Family Commitments

For example: praying together every evening, going to Mass on Sundays, saying thank you at meals, saying sorry to each other before bed, doing one kind act every week.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Signatures of the whole family

Date: _____

A Closing Prayer

To close this guide, here is a prayer to say together, for example on Sunday evening. With this prayer, you entrust your family to Jesus, Mary, and Joseph.

Prayer to the Holy Family

Jesus, Mary and Joseph,
in you we contemplate
the splendour of true love;
to you we turn with trust.
Holy Family of Nazareth,
grant that our families too
may be places of communion and prayer,
authentic schools of the Gospel
and small domestic churches.
Holy Family of Nazareth,
may families never again experience
violence, rejection and division;
may all who have been hurt or scandalized
find ready comfort and healing.
Holy Family of Nazareth,
make us once more mindful
of the sacredness and inviolability of the family,
and its beauty in God's plan.
Jesus, Mary and Joseph,
Graciously hear our prayer.
Amen.

Bonus 1 · Catholic Prayers for Children, p. 21

May God bless your family!